

Marsh, Ferry, Shrine Gate: Asakusa and Ryogoku Across the Sumida

A river crossing on the edge of the old province became a temple town with a shogun's patronage on one bank, and a rebuilt-in-wood pleasure quarter on the other. Fire, flood, earthquake and a single night of firebombing have each remade this ground; a park, a bridge and a bell still mark where the worst of it happened.



浅草・両国（東京都台東区・墨田区）

In this dossier

1. A history of the district (7 chapters, about 2000 words)
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Written in English from Japanese library sources — chiefly books digitised by the National Diet Library — and official records. Superscript numbers point to the numbered sources at the end, with page frames for the digitised books.

Marsh, ferry and a river without a fixed mouth

Long before Edo existed, this ground was where a river met a bay. The Geospatial Information Authority's landform classification reads over a third of the study area as former water and sandbar, more again as former flood plain, and nearly all of it as later artificial fill; a 1914 gazetteer of Asakusa Ward says the same in words, describing a tidal inlet meeting reed marsh and shifting sandbars, with the Sumida then still carrying part of the lower Tone River's flow and running far wider than today. Mount Matsuchiyama, now Asakusa's only hill, is described in the same source as a remnant: once joined to the Ueno and Yushima uplands as one ridge, cut off and worn to an island-like knoll before the land around it filled back in. ¹³¹⁶¹⁷

A ferry crossing here mattered before any temple did. The gazetteer traces how the ancient Tokaido road, unable to cross Tokyo Bay safely from the Miura Peninsula, was rerouted through Musashi province in the Nara period, crossing the Sumida near today's Asakusabashi; an imperial document of 835 records the ferry post here being given two extra boats, four in total, evidence of heavy traffic. The Ise Monogatari's tale of Ariwara no Narihira questioning a miyakodori bird, and the chronicle Azuma Kagami's account of Minamoto no Yoritomo ferrying more than thirty thousand men across here in 1180, are both tied by the gazetteer to this same crossing, long before either bank carried a permanent town. ¹

A shogun's gift: Sensoji and the temple town

Sensoji dates its own founding precisely: on the 18th day of the third month of 628, two brothers, Hinokuma Hamanari and Takenari, are said to have netted a small Kannon statue while fishing the Sumida, and a local official, Haji no Nakachi, began its worship. In 645 the priest Shokai is said to have built it a hall and, after a vision, sealed the image away as a hidden Buddha never shown to worshippers, a practice kept to this day. By the early Kamakura period the temple was substantial enough to appear in the Azuma Kagami, the 1914 gazetteer notes, even where its own earlier tradition is harder to check. ¹⁷

What turned a regional temple into a district's center was the Tokugawa house. Taking the Kanto region in 1590, Ieyasu was advised, an old temple document copied into the gazetteer says, that Sensoji stood in the unlucky northeast from his new castle and had long been venerated by Minamoto generals, and so deserved shogunal patronage; his protection that year grew into a five-hundred-koku grant. Rebuilding the castle meant clearing temples from its path — a contemporary record, the Tensho Nikki, counted at least sixteen moved from Kyobashi alone — and Asakusa, then open ground, absorbed a large share. Commoners gathered at their gates and market stalls opened on temple land; the gazetteer describes the streets from Kaminarimon to the Ueno plateau's foot, and from Asakusabashi to Komagata, as grown directly out of these temple-gate towns, of which the ward held over a hundred before the Restoration, out of some two hundred temples in all. ¹²

Sensoji's own halls burned and rose again repeatedly under this patronage: rebuilt from 1635, burned again in 1642 by a fire from a shop in its own gate-town, and rebuilt once more, the shogunate ordering every hall rebuilt rather than only the main hall the temple had asked for; the work was finished on the 21st day of the twelfth month of 1649 by the old calendar (January 1650 by the modern one), a sequence the gazetteer sets out from the temple's archives and its own modern chronology confirms independently. South along the river, the shogunate's Kuramae rice granaries supported an economy of fudasashi, brokers who turned samurai stipends into cash and, a 1910 guide to the ward records, grew wealthy using the river's barges to do it. The temple took its present name only in 1868; the ward still counted 296 temples in 1882 and 281 in 1912, the most of any Tokyo ward, and Sensoji's main hall and pagoda were declared National Treasures in 1911. ¹²³⁶

Across the river: fire, a bridge and Honjo's pleasure ground

The Sumida's far bank owes its town to catastrophe. The 1657 Meireki fire, also called the Furisode Fire, burned most of Edo and killed over a hundred thousand people whose bodies no family could claim; the fourth shogun, Ietsuna, had them buried together on the Honjo shore that year and founded a temple over the grave, Shoshuzan Muennji Ekoin, dedicated to showing

compassion to all beings regardless of kinship. It later took in the dead of the 1855 Ansei earthquake, the 1923 earthquake and the 1945 firebombing too, along with drowned sailors, executed criminals and animals, a role continued for more than three and a half centuries.¹²

The bridge that followed the fire made the crossing permanent and named the place: Ryogoku, "both provinces," for its linking of Musashi and Shimosa. Begun in 1658 and completed in the twelfth month of 1659 by the old calendar, it and the cleared ground around it grew within a generation into what Sumida City's own account calls Edo's premier entertainment ground — sideshow booths, street performers, small theaters and food stalls at both ends of the bridge, and summer fireworks over the river among the city's best-known sights. Sumo shared the same ground: Ekoin hosted the city's licensed tournaments for seventy-six years into the Meiji era, an age still remembered as "Ekoin sumo," and its Chikarazuka mound still stands, where wrestlers pray for strength before the sumo hall a short walk away today. Sumo outgrew the temple grounds in 1909, when a purpose-built hall, the Kokugikan, was completed in Ryogoku; in 1950 the tournaments moved to Kuramae in Taito Ward, where a new Kokugikan opened in 1954, and they came back to Ryogoku only in January 1985, when the present hall opened.^{12 13 20 21}

A park, a tower and the Sixth District

Meiji's government confiscated most temple land nationwide, and Sensoji did not escape: of roughly 114,500 tsubo it still held at the Restoration, all but 6,368 tsubo of its Denboin residence were taken, and in 1873 that ground became Asakusa Park, within four decades the busiest single spot in Tokyo, the 1914 gazetteer records. The park was divided into numbered districts, and by 1910 its Sixth, remembered ever after as Rokku, held a dense row of variety theaters — the Tokiwaza on its own numbered lot, and others such as the Horaiza and Kaiseiza, each with a named proprietor and an audience capacity in the hundreds or low thousands, a prosperity guide to the ward records.¹³

The most literal symbol of that modernity stood beside the theaters. The twelve-story Ryouunkaku observation tower was built in 1890; the National Film Archive of Japan's account of surviving newsreel footage records its collapse from the eighth floor upward in the 1923 earthquake, and its demolition by an army engineering unit's controlled explosion on 23 September that year, an eyewitness account by the physicist Torahiko Terada describing it breaking into a few large fragments before crumbling to powder.¹¹

1923: the Clothing Depot

The Great Kanto earthquake struck at 11:58 a.m. on 1 September 1923, its epicenter under Sagami Bay; in Asakusa and Honjo it turned an unfinished park into the city's single worst disaster site. The ground had been an Army Clothing Depot until handed over in stages from March 1922; Tokyo City bought some 6,279 tsubo of it that month, budgeted construction in April 1923, and broke ground that July on what its planners called the capital's first modern mid-sized park, meant to give the green-space-poor Koto districts somewhere to exercise. Two months into construction, the earthquake sent tens of thousands fleeing there with their belongings; the memorial association's own 1934 account describes the roughly twenty-thousand-tsubo ground packed "with no room to set a foot down," and when wind-driven fire caught the piled goods alight, some thirty thousand died there in less than an hour, unable to move in the crush.^{4 5}

The dead here have never produced one number, because records counted different things. The association's 1932 report tallies 58,656 bodies cremated across thirteen city sites that September, 49,821 of them, by its own figures, at this site alone; a separate roll of individually named victims, checked against public notices from 1927 to 1929, records 38,826 names in twenty volumes. Today the park's own managing authority gives "about 38,000" as the dead at this one location, the figure now most often quoted. This dossier gives all three counts, since they answer different questions: bodies burned here, names confirmed, and lives thought lost on this ground itself.^{4 5 8}

A provisional ossuary went up within weeks; the permanent Memorial Hall took seven years, opening with the renamed Yokoamicho Park on 1 September 1930. Its architect, Ito Chuta, was engaged after the association's own open design competition ended without an adopted winner, and built in reinforced concrete a design that deliberately mixes traditions —

Shinto and Buddhist forms outside, a pagoda-like tower drawing on Chinese and Indian precedent, a basilica-like colonnade inside — standing 20.9 meters at the hall and 40.9 at the tower.⁸⁹

1945 and after: rebuilding twice

The vulnerability 1923 had exposed was not corrected before the next war reached Tokyo. A citywide "building thinning" firebreak-demolition program, begun in 1944, had pulled down some 55,000 households' homes by that July, but proved hopeless on the night of 9-10 March 1945, when American bombers ringed the working-class wards east of the palace with incendiaries to block escape, then saturated the interior; Japan's own Ministry of Internal Affairs and Communications cites the Metropolitan Police Department's 1962 history for a toll of about 267,000 houses burned and roughly 84,000 dead in that single raid, one of 122 the city endured. Asakusa and Honjo lay at the center of the burned area: Sensoji's hall, gate, pagoda and sutra repository, standing since the Edo rebuildings and the 1911 National Treasure listing, all burned that night.⁶¹⁰

In March 1947 the war-battered capital reorganized its wards: Asakusa merged with Shitaya to form Taito, and across the river Honjo merged with Mukojima to form Sumida, part of a citywide fall from thirty-five wards to twenty-two, driven by wartime population shifts and a new local-autonomy law. The unidentified dead of the March raids, some 105,000 of them, were later placed in the same Memorial Hall that already held the 1923 remains; renamed the Tokyo Metropolitan Memorial Hall in September 1951, it has commemorated both disasters jointly ever since, on 10 March and 1 September each year.^{810 14 15}

Sensoji's own recovery took over a decade: a new main hall in 1958, the Kaminarimon gate — absent for close to a century — in 1960, the rebuilt Hozomon inner gate in 1964, and a new pagoda in 1973, the sequence recorded in the temple's own chronology. On the Sumida side, more recent landmarks sit within a few minutes of Ekoin and the park: the Sumida Hokusai Museum, designed by Kazuyo Sejima and opened in 2016 near where the artist Katsushika Hokusai lived out his life, and Tokyo Skytree, a 634-meter tower at Oshiage that reached full height in March 2011 and opened in May 2012, visible over the rooftops from almost anywhere in the study area.⁶¹⁸¹⁹

Reading the ground today

Little of the pre-Edo shoreline survives to the eye, but its logic still shapes the map: Matsuchiyama's isolated knoll, the only rise for some distance in a district classed as almost entirely former water, sandbar and fill, marks where solid ground first appeared, and the streets radiating from Sensoji's gate still trace the old temple-gate towns rather than any planned grid. Kuramae's riverside, once lined with shogunal granaries and fudasashi brokers, is unmarked today but still readable in the embankment road's width and the narrow lot lines running back from it.¹³¹⁶¹⁷

Across the river, the two great disaster sites lie a few hundred meters apart: the lanes around Ekoin, rebuilt after the Meireki fire and again after 1945, still run close and narrow in the old entertainment-quarter pattern, while Yokoamicho Park opens out as the largest clear space in the district, its outline the Army Clothing Depot ground the city had bought for a park before the earthquake. Setting the historical and present-day aerial photography included elsewhere in this dossier package side by side over these same few hundred meters shows how little the park's outline has moved since 1930, even as almost every building around it has since been replaced at least twice.¹⁶

Timeline

628	Traditional founding of Sensoji, after two brothers are said to have netted a Kannon statue in the Sumida. ⁷
1590	Tokugawa Ieyasu grants Sensoji a black-seal protection document on entering the Kanto region; a 500-koku stipend follows. ¹
1649	Sensoji's halls, rebuilt after a 1642 fire, are completed late in the year (January 1650 by the modern calendar). ¹⁶
1657	The Meireki fire kills over 100,000 in Edo; Ekoin is founded on the Honjo shore to bury the unclaimed dead. ¹²
1658-59	Ryogoku Bridge is built across the Sumida (completed in the twelfth month of 1659 by the old calendar), and the ground around it becomes Edo's leading entertainment quarter. ^{13 20}
1873	Sensoji's confiscated precinct is designated Asakusa Park under the new Meiji government. ¹
1890	The twelve-story Ryounkaku observation tower opens in Asakusa Park. ¹¹
1 September 1923	The Great Kanto earthquake strikes; a firestorm on the former Army Clothing Depot site kills tens of thousands sheltering there. ^{4 5}
1930	Yokoamicho Park and its Memorial Hall, designed by Ito Chuta, open on the Clothing Depot site. ^{8 9}
9-10 March 1945	American incendiary bombing destroys most of Asakusa and Honjo overnight, burning Sensoji's hall, gate and pagoda; officially about 84,000 die citywide. ^{6 10}
1947	Tokyo's ward reorganization creates Taito (from Asakusa and Shitaya) and Sumida (from Honjo and Mukojima). ^{14 15}
1951	The Memorial Hall is renamed the Tokyo Metropolitan Memorial Hall after remains of about 105,000 unidentified air-raid dead are added. ⁸
1958-1973	Sensoji is rebuilt in stages: main hall (1958), Kaminarimon gate (1960), Hozomon inner gate (1964), five-story pagoda (1973). ⁶
2012-2016	Tokyo Skytree opens at Oshiage (2012) and the Sumida Hokusai Museum opens nearby (2016). ^{18 19}

Walking notes

Places to stand and look, in walking order. Straight-line distances only; check today's access and opening before you go.

- 1

Kaminarimon and Nakamise-dori

雷門・仲見世通り

The outer gate, rebuilt in 1960 after standing without one for nearly a century, opens onto the shopping street that grew out of Sensoji's medieval temple-gate town.²⁶ [map](#)
- 2

Sensoji main hall and five-story pagoda

浅草寺本堂・五重塔

Rebuilt in reinforced concrete in 1958 and 1973, after the 1945 firebombing destroyed structures that had stood since the Edo period and had been declared National Treasures in 1911.⁶ [map](#)
- 3

Azuma Bridge and the Sumida embankment

吾妻橋・隅田川テラス

Near the old ferry crossing described in the ward gazetteer's account of the ancient Tokaido road and the ferry post recorded here in 835; the riverside terrace and Skytree's tower are both visible from the same span.¹¹⁸ [map](#)
- 4

Kuramae riverside

蔵前

Site of the shogunate's rice granaries and the fudasashi brokers who financed samurai households; no structure survives, but the long, narrow lot lines running back from the embankment road echo the old warehouse plan.³ [map](#)
- 5

Ekoin Temple

回向院

Founded in 1657 to bury the Meireki fire's unclaimed dead and still receiving disaster victims into the twentieth century; the Chikarazuka mound recalls its 76 years as Edo and Meiji Japan's licensed sumo

venue.¹² [map](#)

- 6 **Yokoamicho Park and the Tokyo Metropolitan Memorial Hall** 横網町公園・東京都慰霊堂. Built on the former Army Clothing Depot site where tens of thousands died in the 1923 firestorm; Ito Chuta's 1930 hall now holds remains from both that disaster and the 1945 air raids.⁸⁹ [map](#)

Walk map



The walking stops, numbered as in the notes, on the latest GSI aerial photograph (3.9 × 2.8 km, north up). Lines join the stops in order and are not a route; follow streets on the ground. Each stop in the notes links to a map app.

- | | | | |
|---|--|---|---|
| 1 | Kaminarimon and Nakamise-dori map | 4 | Kuramae riverside map |
| 2 | Sensoji main hall and five-story pagoda map | 5 | Ekoin Temple map |
| 3 | Azuma Bridge and the Sumida embankment map | 6 | Yokoamicho Park and the Tokyo Metropolitan Memorial Hall map |

The stops today

Recent photographs of the stops, numbered as in the walking notes. Each was checked against the place the note describes; the line under the name says what it shows.



1. Kaminarimon and Nakamise-dori

Kaminarimon, Sensoji's outer gate, with its large red lantern

"Kaminarimon (outer gate), Sensoji Temple, Akakusa, Tokyo" by Daderot, Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons



2. Sensoji main hall and five-story pagoda

The main hall of Sensoji, seen from the courtyard in front

"Sensoji 2023" by Akonnchiroll, CC0, via Wikimedia Commons



3. Azuma Bridge and the Sumida embankment

The red Azuma Bridge over the Sumida, with the Asahi Beer head office and Skytree

"Azuma Bridge 2" by Kakidai, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons



4. Kuramae riverside

No reusable ground-level photograph shows this place, so here is the latest GSI aerial photograph of the spot (ringed), north up, about 480 m across.

Aerial photograph: Geospatial Information Authority of Japan (GSI), seamless aerial photos



5. Ekoin Temple

The Chikarazuka monument at Ekoin on its walled platform, with stone lanterns

"Sumo monuments in Ekoin 2008 August" by Morio, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons



6. Yokoamicho Park and the Tokyo Metropolitan Memorial Hall

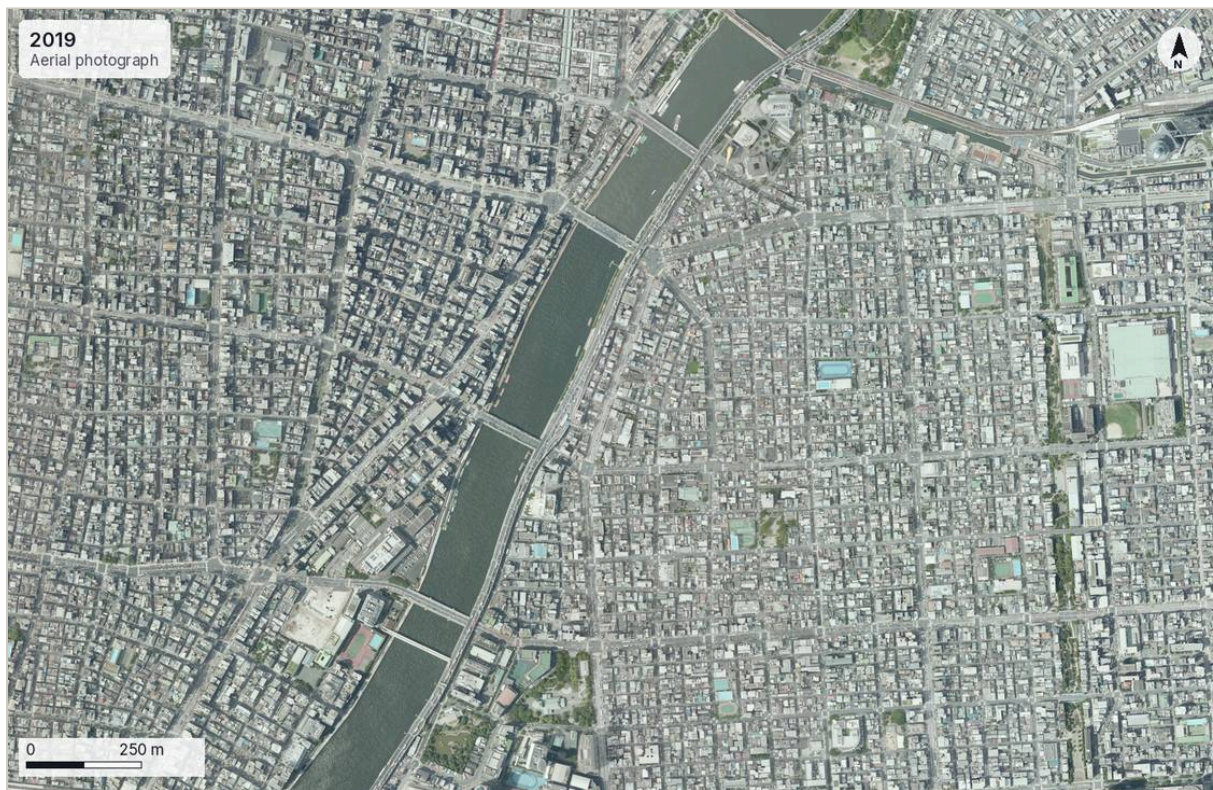
The Tokyo Metropolitan Memorial Hall in Yokoamicho Park

"Tokyo Memorial Hall" by Lcsshiller, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons

The same ground, c. 1936–1942 and 2019



c. 1936–1942 aerial photograph — GSI Tiles *ort_riku10*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. North is up; the frame is identical in both images.



2019 annual orthophoto — GSI Tiles *nendophoto2019*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. Capture dates within a mosaic can differ from place to place.

How to compare. Anchor on features that rarely move — river banks, rail lines, shrine and temple grounds, main roads — then look for what changed around them. Differences in tone come from film, camera and season, not from the land itself.

The decades in between

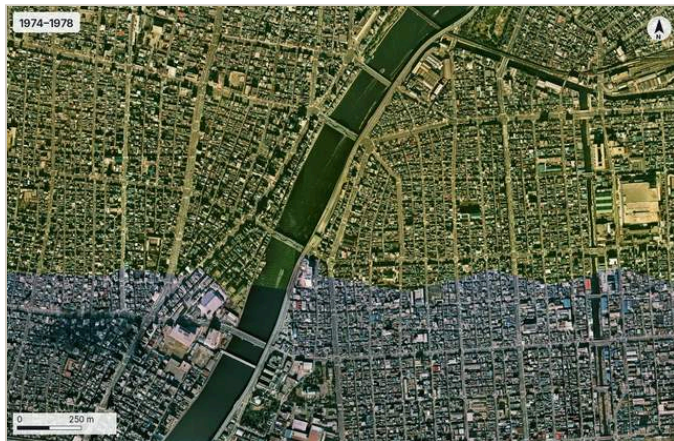
Every further GSI series that covers the same frame, oldest first. Each series is a compilation: photographs within one series were taken on different dates, which is why seams and changes of tone can appear inside a frame.



1945–1950 (US military photography) · GSI Tiles *ort_USA10*, processed



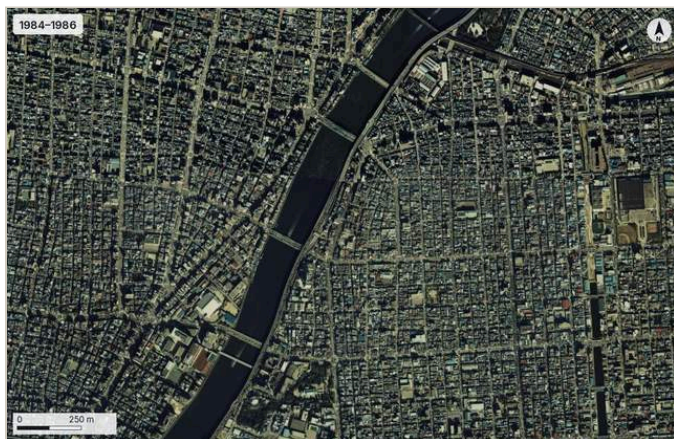
1961–1969 · GSI Tiles *ort_old10*, processed



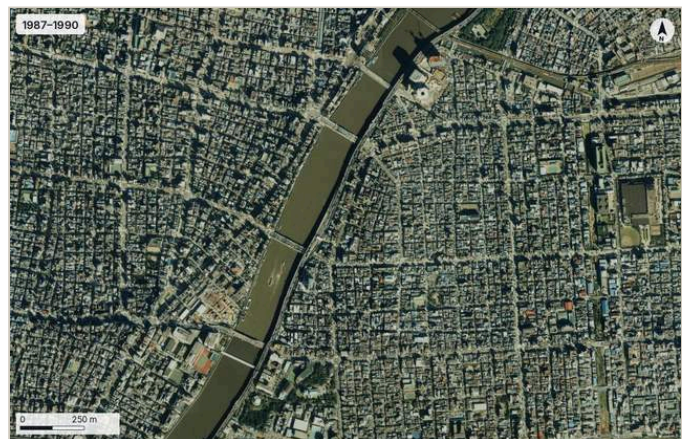
1974–1978 · GSI Tiles *gazo1*, processed



1979–1983 · GSI Tiles *gazo2*, processed



1984–1986 · GSI Tiles *gazo3*, processed



1987–1990 · GSI Tiles *gazo4*, processed

Rivers, shorelines and terraces



Natural landforms as classified by GSI, over a recent aerial photograph in gray. Dark blue outlines mark former river channels.



What the main landforms mean

Former water area (38%). Land shown by old maps and aerial photographs to have been sea, lake, pond, reservoir or river, later turned into land. Soft ground: very strong liquefaction tendency where filled, strong where drained. Storm surge near the coast.

Sandbars and dunes (28%). Sandy or gravelly ground higher than its surroundings along present or former coasts, lakeshores and riverbanks, built by waves or wind. Usually escapes ordinary floods. Liquefaction tendency is somewhat strong on sandbars, somewhat weak on dunes and very strong at dune margins.

Floodplain and coastal plain (27%). Low, flat ground of little relief, built from sand and mud left by floods, or former seabed that emerged. River flooding. Ground is softer nearer the coast and shakes somewhat more; liquefaction tendency is strong on coastal plains and somewhat strong on floodplains. Storm surge near the coast.

Descriptions translated and condensed from GSI's landform-classification legend. They describe tendencies of each landform type, not the condition of any individual plot.

Fill, reclamation and the fields beneath the town



Hatching: man-made ground as classified by GSI. Teal outlines: former sea, river or pond. Dark blue outlines: former river channels.



GSI “Meiji-era lowland” data, traced from topographic maps of the 1880s–1900s; GSI warns that positions can be off by a considerable distance, especially in the Kanto and Kinki regions. Only low, wet or open ground was traced: towns, dry fields and forest of the period are left blank.

Man-made ground

 Filled and reclaimed land 91%

Meiji-era lowland

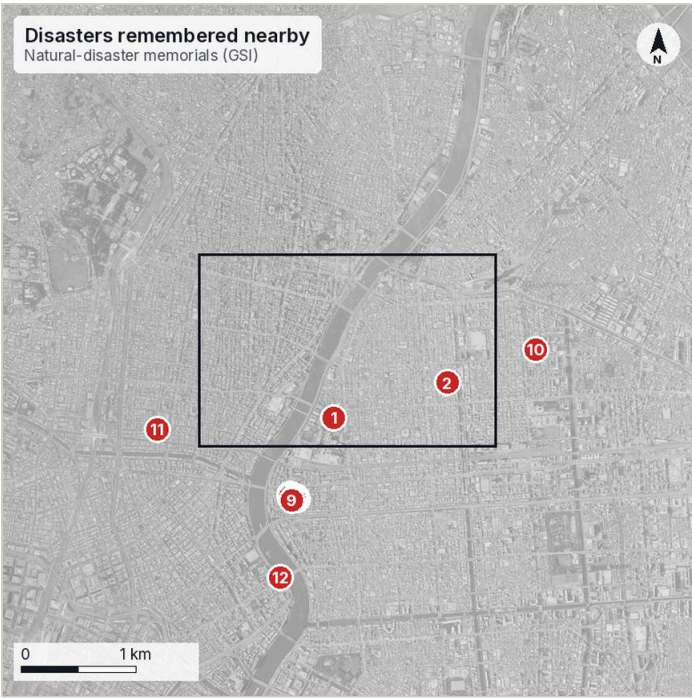
 River, pond or sea 11%

 Rice paddy 3.9%

 Thatch-grass fields 0.7%

Filled and reclaimed land (91%). Ground raised with fill, land made by dumping soil into the sea, rivers or ponds, or valleys filled in. May flood if not raised enough; on hills, rain or earthquakes can make the fill fail; in lowlands the liquefaction tendency is very strong, especially on filled sea, lake or river beds.

Memorials to natural disasters nearby



Numbered memorials; the black rectangle is the study area of this brief. Frame 6 km across.

	Memorial	Disaster	Erected	Distance
1	Memorial to the Ishiware-cho victims of the 1923 Great Kanto Earthquake fire 大正大震災火災石原町遭難者碑	Great Kanto Earthquake (1 Sep 1923) · earthquake	1925	0.6 km
2	Memorial to the victims of the 1923 Great Kanto Earthquake fire 大震災遭難者追悼之碑	Great Kanto Earthquake (1 Sep 1923) · earthquake	1931	0.9 km
3	Stone Jizo statue for the Tatekawa riverbank victims of the 1923 earthquake fire 大震災火災堅川岸遭難者追善石造地藏菩薩立像	Great Kanto Earthquake (1 Sep 1923) · earthquake	1924	1.4 km
4	Grave of those killed in the 1923 Great Kanto Earthquake 大震災横死者之墓(関東大地震横死者供養碑)	Great Kanto Earthquake (1 Sep 1923) · earthquake	unknown	1.4 km
5	Memorial to those crushed to death in the 1855 Ansei Edo earthquake 安政江戸地震圧死者供養塔	Ansei Edo earthquake (11 Nov 1855) · earthquake	1856	1.4 km
6	Memorial to those killed in the two Ansei disasters of 1855 and 1856 安政二年・三年両度天災横死諸靈魂追善供養塔	Ansei Edo earthquake (11 Nov 1855) and Ansei Edo typhoon (23 Sep 1856) · earthquake / other	1857	1.4 km
7	Memorial to all who died in the 1855 Ansei Edo earthquake and its fires 地震焼亡横死諸群靈塔	Ansei Edo earthquake (11 Nov 1855) · earthquake	1866	1.4 km
8	Memorial to the victims of the 1783 Mount Asama eruption in Shinshu and Joshu 天明三年癸卯七月七日八日信州上州地変横死之諸靈魂等供養塔	Tenmei eruption of Mount Asama (4 Aug 1783) · volcanic disaster	1785	1.4 km
9	Memorial to those killed in the disasters since the 1783 Mount Asama eruption 信州浅間山噴火以来天災横死者供養塔	Tenmei eruption of Mount Asama (4 Aug 1783) and later disasters · volcanic disaster / other	1789	1.4 km
10	Memorial to Aioi Police Station officers who died on duty in the 1923 earthquake fire 大震災火災相生警察署員殉職之碑	Great Kanto Earthquake (1 Sep 1923) · earthquake	1933	1.6 km
11	Monument to the neighborhood defended from fire in 1923 防火守護地の碑	Great Kanto Earthquake (1 Sep 1923) · earthquake	1968	1.8 km
12	Memorial to those who found refuge at Shin-Ohashi Bridge in 1923 避難記念	Great Kanto Earthquake (1 Sep 1923) · earthquake	1933	2.1 km

What the memorials record

1. Memorial to the Ishiwara-cho victims of the 1923 Great Kanto Earthquake fire. The fires that followed the Great Kanto Earthquake of 1 September 1923 reduced most of the city to ashes; Honjo and Fukagawa wards suffered worst, and countless lives were lost. Of about 8,000 residents of Ishiwara-cho in Honjo Ward, about 7,000 burned to death. The stone was relocated in 1931.

2. Memorial to the victims of the 1923 Great Kanto Earthquake fire. The Honjo area suffered enormous damage in the Great Kanto Earthquake of 1 September 1923. A memorial to the victims was erected in March 1931; because it was damaged during the air raid on Tokyo of 10 March 1945, the present stone was rebuilt in 1961.

3. Stone Jizo statue for the Tatekawa riverbank victims of the 1923 earthquake fire. On the afternoon of 1 September 1923, the day of the Great Kanto Earthquake, several hundred people on the Tatekawa riverbank, trapped by black smoke and fierce flames, threw themselves into the river, and many drowned; many others burned to death. The Jizo was erected in November 1924, and its base inscription dedicates it to these victims.

4. Grave of those killed in the 1923 Great Kanto Earthquake. Probably erected for victims of the Great Kanto Earthquake of 1 September 1923 in the Ryogoku police district. Its inscriptions give the date, "ninety-odd" dead and the donor, the Aioi Barbers' Association, and record a gift of 50 yen to the temple for memorial services.

5. Memorial to those crushed to death in the 1855 Ansei Edo earthquake. Around 10 pm on 11 November 1855 a great earthquake struck Edo, and tens of thousands of people were crushed or burned to death. According to the inscription, a group of plasterers from Azabu planned this memorial to ease the victims' suffering, and the high priest of Zojoji, praising their aim, wrote the invocation "Namu Amida Butsu" for it.

6. Memorial to those killed in the two Ansei disasters of 1855 and 1856. The Ansei Edo earthquake of 11 November 1855 brought down houses and storehouses and started fires in dozens of places; on 23 September 1856 a typhoon flattened houses and riverside floods swept others away. Many were crushed, burned or drowned. Carved with six Jizo figures, the memorial was set up in 1857 for the dead of both disasters.

Source: GSI Natural Disaster Memorials (自然災害伝承碑). English names and notes are Japan Time Atlas translations and summaries of GSI's Japanese descriptions; the memorials' own inscriptions may say more. "Erected" is the year GSI records for the monument.

Sources

1. 東京市浅草区 (Tokyo City, Asakusa Ward), 浅草区誌 上巻 [Gazetteer of Asakusa Ward, vol. 1], 1914; NDL frames 38, 39, 372, 373, 374, 375. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/950733/1/38> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: Pre-Edo geography and the Sumida ferry crossing; Sensoji's 1590 shogunal patronage and hall rebuildings 1635-1649; the 1873 confiscation and creation of Asakusa Park.
2. 東京市浅草区 (Tokyo City, Asakusa Ward), 浅草区誌 下巻 [Gazetteer of Asakusa Ward, vol. 2], 1914; NDL frames 109, 110, 111, 112. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/950734/1/109> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: Buddhist temples chapter: Ieyasu's 1590 temple relocations, formation of monzen-machi, temple numbers 1882-1912.
3. 松山伝十郎編 (Matsuyama Denjuro, ed.), 浅草繁昌記 [The Prosperity of Asakusa], 1910; NDL frames 21, 22, 23, 97. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/763562/1/21> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: Ward topography and flood history; Sensoji's founding tradition and 942 revival; Kuramae's fudasashi rice brokers; the Sixth District (Rokku) theaters in 1910.
4. 東京震災記念事業協会清算事務所編 (Tokyo Earthquake Memorial Project Association, Liquidation Office, ed.), 被服廠跡：東京震災記念事業協会事業報告 [Ruins of the Army Clothing Depot: report of the Tokyo Earthquake Memorial Project Association], 1932; NDL frames 17, 18, 59, 60, 90, 91. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1273030/1/17> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: The earthquake and the Clothing Depot site's history as a planned park; official count of 58,656 bodies cremated citywide, 49,821 at this site.
5. 東京震災記念事業協会 (Tokyo Earthquake Memorial Project Association), 被服廠跡 [Ruins of the Army Clothing Depot], 1934; NDL frames 12, 27, 30, 35. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1454627/1/12> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: Eyewitness account of the disaster; the 1929 roll of 38,826 named victims; the association's own estimate of about 30,000 dead within the hour on this ground.
6. 略式年表 [Sensoji: chronology], 金龍山浅草寺 (Sensoji Temple). <https://www.senso-ji.jp/about/chronology.html>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Full chronology of Sensoji's destructions and rebuildings, 1041-1973, including the 1945 firebombing and postwar reconstruction dates.
7. 浅草寺の歴史 [Sensoji: history], 金龍山浅草寺 (Sensoji Temple). <https://www.senso-ji.jp/about/>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Founding legend (628) and the hidden-Buddha tradition established in 645.
8. 都立横網町公園の歴史 [History of Yokoamicho Park], 東京都慰霊協会 (Tokyo Metropolitan Memorial Association). <https://tokyoireikyokai.or.jp/park/history.html>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Site history, the 1923 firestorm and its "about 38,000" dead, the 1930 opening and 1951 renaming with air-raid dead added.
9. 慰霊堂の歴史 [History of the Tokyo Metropolitan Memorial Hall], 東京都慰霊協会 (Tokyo Metropolitan Memorial Association). <https://tokyoireikyokai.or.jp/ireidou/history.html>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Architect Ito Chuta, the 1930 completion, building dimensions and design description.
10. 東京都における戦災の状況 (東京) [The state of war damage in Tokyo], 総務省 (Ministry of Internal Affairs and Communications). https://www.soumu.go.jp/main_sosiki/daijinkanbou/sensai/situation/state/kanto_11.html, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Building-thinning program; official figures for the 9-10 March 1945 raid (about 267,000 houses burned, about 84,000 dead) from the 1962 Metropolitan Police history; the 122 total raids; the 1951 renaming of the Memorial Hall.
11. 関東大震災記録映像の撮影場所ー浅草十二階を手がかりにー [Locating Great Kanto earthquake newsreel footage, using the Asakusa Twelve-Storey Tower as a clue], 国立映画アーカイブ (National Film Archive of Japan). <https://kantodaishinsai.filmarchives.jp/columns/c01.html>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Ryounkaku's 1890 construction, its collapse on 1 September 1923, and its demolition by military engineers on 23 September 1923.
12. 回向院 [Ekoin Temple], 東京都観光公式サイトGO TOKYO (Tokyo Convention & Visitors Bureau). <https://www.gotokyo.org/jp/spot/912/index.html>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Ekoin's 1657 founding after the Meireki fire, its role in later disasters, and its 76 years as the licensed sumo venue.
13. 両国の賑わい [The bustle of Ryogoku], 墨田区 (Sumida City). https://www.city.sumida.lg.jp/sisetu_info/siryoku/kyoudobunka/sonota/tenzi/h11/ryougoku.html, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Ryogoku Bridge's 1658 construction and the entertainment quarter that grew up around it.
14. 台東区の歩み [The formation of Taito City], 台東区 (Taito City). <https://www.city.taito.lg.jp/kusei/shokai/abouttaito/profile/naritai.html>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Taito City's formation on 15 March 1947 from Shitaya and Asakusa wards.
15. 大東京35区物語 - 15区から23区へ - 東京23区の歴史 [The story of Greater Tokyo's 35 wards: from 15 to 23 wards], 東京都総務局 (Tokyo Metropolitan Government, General Affairs Bureau). https://www.soumu.metro.tokyo.lg.jp/01soumu-archives/07edo_tokyo/0714tokyo_ku, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The citywide 1947 reorganization from 35 to 22 (then 23) wards and its stated causes.
16. 地理院タイル 空中写真 (米軍撮影ほか) 及び全国最新写真 (シームレス) [GSI Tiles: aerial photographs (including US forces) and current seamless photographs], 国土地理院 (Geospatial Information Authority of Japan). <https://maps.gsi.go.jp/development/ichiran.html>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Basis for comparing the historical and present-day aerial photographs of the study area, including Yokoamicho Park's outline.
17. 地形分類 (自然地形・人工地形) ベクトルタイル [Landform classification (natural and artificial) vector tiles], 国土地理院 (Geospatial Information Authority of Japan). https://github.com/gsi-cyberjapan/experimental_landformclassification, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Classification of the study area as former water, sandbar and flood plain, now mostly artificial fill.

18. *TOKYO SKYTREE*沿革 [Tokyo Skytree: history and timeline], 東武タワースカイツリー株式会社 (Tobu Tower Skytree Co., Ltd.). <https://en.tokyo-skytree.jp/about/timeline/>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Site selection in Oshiage, Sumida (2005), maximum height reached (2011) and public opening (22 May 2012).
19. すみだ北斎美術館 [Sumida Hokusai Museum], 東京都観光公式サイトGO TOKYO (Tokyo Convention & Visitors Bureau). <https://www.gotokyo.org/jp/spot/138/index.html>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The museum's 2016 opening, its architect, and its connection to Hokusai's life in the area.
20. 墨田区の通史年表 [Chronology of Sumida], 墨田区 (Sumida City). https://www.city.sumida.lg.jp/sisetu_info/siryoku/kyoudobunka/sonota/mame/tuusi.html, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Ryogoku Bridge begun 1658 and completed in the twelfth month of 1659; sumo at Ekoin from 1833; the Kokugikan completed 1909; the move to Kuramae 1950; the return to Ryogoku in January 1985.
21. 過去の展示 - 平成26年 [Sumo Museum past exhibitions, 2014], 日本相撲協会 (Japan Sumo Association). <https://www.sumo.or.jp/KokugikanSumoMuseumDisplay/past?year=2014>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The Kuramae Kokugikan opened in 1954; the museum moved when the Ryogoku Kokugikan was completed in 1985.

Further reading

- *本所区史 (東京市本所区編, 1931)* — The old Honjo Ward's own history, for street-level detail on Ryogoku and the Clothing Depot area not covered here. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1192510> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))
- *台東区史上 (台東区編, 1955)* — Taito City's own postwar history of the former Asakusa and Shitaya wards. <https://ndlsearch.ndl.go.jp/books/R100000002-I000000941482> (print only)
- *墨田区史 (東京都墨田区役所編, 1959)* — Sumida City's own history of the former Honjo and Mukojima wards, including its 1947 formation. <https://ndlsearch.ndl.go.jp/books/R100000001-I1211000000616566> (print only)
- *下谷浅草町名由来考 (台東区, 1967)* — A dedicated study of Asakusa's old town names, cited by Taito City's own library reference service. <http://iss.ndl.go.jp/books/R100000001-I077971917-00> (NDL premises only)
- *江戸浅草町名の研究 (小森隆吉著, 叢文社, 1984)* — A scholarly study of Asakusa's Edo-period place names, also cited by the Taito Central Library's reference service. <http://iss.ndl.go.jp/books/R100000002-I000001673278-00> (NDL premises only)

Where a Deep Research request would go next

- **The names behind the 1929 roll of 38,826 registered Clothing Depot victims** — Tokyo Metropolitan Archives (東京都公文書館) and the Tokyo Metropolitan Memorial Association. Request access to the surviving volumes of the 霊名簿 (memorial roll) and the association's founding-era administrative files.
- **Ward-level breakdowns of the 9-10 March 1945 raid's casualties in the former Asakusa and Honjo wards specifically** — The Center of the Tokyo Raids and War Damage (東京大空襲・戦災資料センター) and the Taito and Sumida ward archives. Consult their published 戦災誌 (war-damage records) and ward-history supplementary volumes.
- **American mission records and reconnaissance imagery for the 9-10 March 1945 raid over Asakusa and Honjo** — US National Archives (NARA): XXI Bomber Command mission reports (Record Group 18) and US Strategic Bombing Survey files (Record Group 243). Search the NARA online catalog by unit and date; textual and photographic records can be ordered as reproductions.
- **Pre-1923 land-lot ownership of the Army Clothing Depot site and its neighbors** — Tokyo Legal Affairs Bureau (closed land registers, 旧土地台帳) and the Tokyo Metropolitan Archives. Request the old land registers by lot number for former Honjo Ward, Yokoamicho.
- **Fudasashi account books and the Kuramae granary district's daily operation** — National Archives of Japan (国立公文書館) and the Edo-Tokyo Museum's research collections. Search their catalogues for 蔵前 and 札差 and request reading-room access.

Caveats

- Casualty figures for the Army Clothing Depot site differ because different records count different things: 49,821 bodies cremated there (a 1932 official tally), about 30,000 estimated dead within the first hour (a 1934 account), 38,826 individually named and registered victims (finalized 1929), and "about 38,000" as today's park authority's headline figure. This dossier gives all four rather than resolving them into one.
- Sensoji's founding dates (628 for the statue's discovery, 645 for the first hall) rest on the temple's own tradition and are reported here as such, not as independently verified fact. The temple's own history page likewise flags the reading of Haji no Nakachi's name as uncertain ("名前には諸説あり"); other reconstructions include Nakatomo and Manakachi.
- The pairing of Honjo and Mukojima wards into Sumida City in the March 1947 reorganization is well established, but this session confirmed it through search summaries of the reorganization rather than by reading an official page's full text describing that specific merger; the wider 1947 process and Taito City's own formation are independently sourced.

Digitised books are cited, not reproduced: the page frames let you open the same page in the NDL Digital Collections. Aerial photographs, landform and memorial data: GSI, processed by Japan Time Atlas. Positions of the walking stops: © OpenStreetMap contributors (ODbL), found with Nominatim. Photographs of the stops: Wikimedia Commons contributors, under the licences named beside each; scaled, not otherwise altered. This experimental edition was checked against its cited sources on 2026-09-28 but has not had independent fact-checking.